



SECAS Accomplishments & Progress

December 2025 - June 2026

Since 2011, [SECAS](#) has brought together public and private organizations to connect lands and waters for people and nature.

A bold vision: *A connected network of lands and waters that supports thriving fish and wildlife populations and improved quality of life for people across the Southeast and Caribbean.*

An ambitious goal: *improve ecosystem health, function, and connectivity at least 10% by 2060*

A Blueprint for action: *accelerates conservation in the places where it will make the biggest impact*



“SECAS is a unique partner who strives to understand an issue then successfully listens before sketching out the next

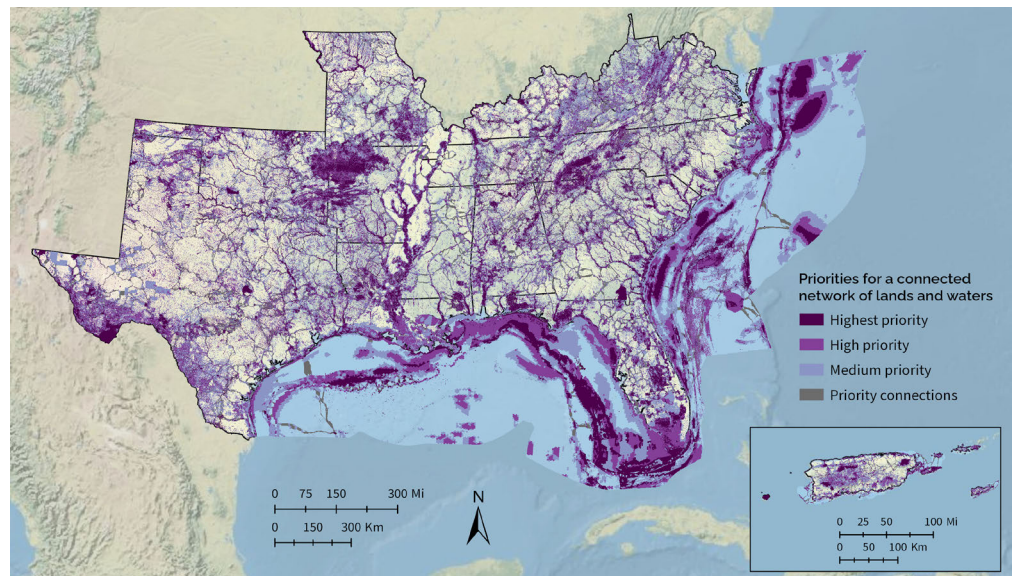
steps for implementation. Their collaborative network is unmatched in the Southeast and beyond, which pays dividends when each state may not be able to articulate what a final project needs to look like or how to get there. SECAS knows activities and a wealth of partners, then how to build and complement those efforts to piece the Southeast’s quilt together in a meaningful way. SECAS’s analytical skills are unmatched, which supports the ability to create scenarios and options that resolve Southeast conservation issues.

—Shannon Deaton, Division Chief of Habitat Conservation at the NC Wildlife Resources Commission & SECAS Point of Contact

2025 Highlights

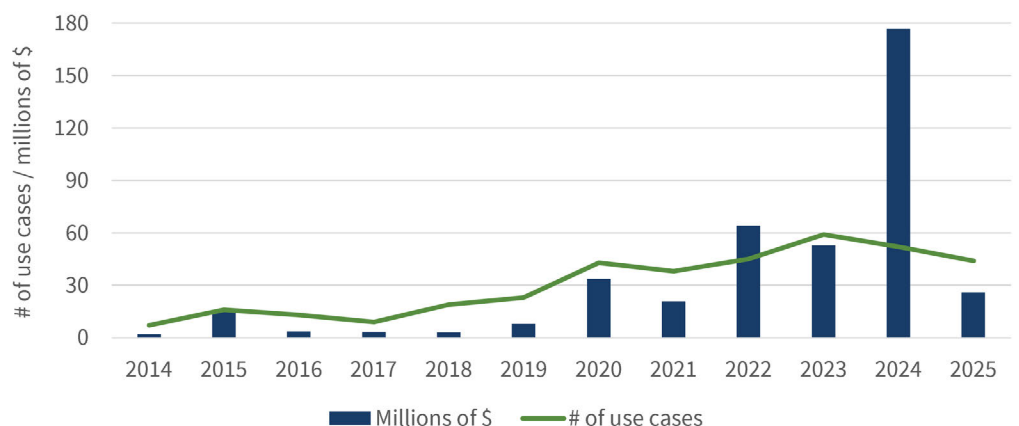
Despite changes to the federal workforce and reduced capacity in 2025, SECAS continues to deliver value. In 2025, SECAS:

- Delivered the 10th annual update to the [Southeast Conservation Blueprint](#), which includes new data representing state priority species, grassland restoration opportunities, and priority areas for river cane (a cultural keystone species for Tribes), as well as corridors that better align with state priorities.
- Helped 10 state and 2 territorial fish and wildlife agencies update their 2025 Wildlife Action Plans to better align across state boundaries (AR, GA, KY, MS, NC, LA, OK, SC, TN, VA, PR, USVI).
- Welcomed two new Steering Committee members: Duck Locascio (LA Dept. of Wildlife and Fisheries) and Kyle Briggs (NC Wildlife Resources Commission).



Southeast Conservation Blueprint 2025. Learn more at secassoutheast.org/blueprint.

Blueprint Impact: Funding and Use Cases Over Time



Since its inception, the Blueprint has contributed to 350+ completed projects and helped bring in \$410+ million to protect and restore 410,000+ acres!

2026 Progress So Far

Due to staff losses, this year SECAS is prioritizing supporting Blueprint users and strengthening partner connections while scaling back Blueprint improvements. SECAS also continues to align work and pursue shared opportunities with neighboring regional conservation partnerships like the Midwest Landscape Initiative.

Working with Partners to Inform Action

Recent examples include:

- Helping the National Fish and Wildlife Foundation pilot the Southeast Forests and Rivers Business Plan—the first of 16 nationwide Next Generation Business Plans—by connecting the Blueprint with state priority areas and species to help shape clear, measurable 30-year conservation goals and align partner investments across forest, grassland, and aquatic systems.
- Working with the Appalachian People and Places Conservation Collaborative to help them integrate the Southeast Blueprint, the Midwest Blueprint, and Nature's Network to identify spatial priorities across this important ecoregion that spans three regional partnership geographies.
- Supporting 10 National Wildlife Refuges along the SC and GA coasts as they use the Blueprint to help seek approval for expanding their boundaries, capitalizing on momentum from [SC Governor McMaster's ambitious goal](#) of conserving 10 million acres statewide.

2026 Southeast Conservation Blueprint Improvements

Blueprint 2026, scheduled for release in the fall, will include:

- New coverage of aquatic Species of Greatest Conservation Need (SGCN) in the U.S. Caribbean.
- Updated data for mammal, reptile, and amphibian Regional SGCN in the continental Southeast.
- Improved representation of fire-adapted forests and grasslands on the continent, including regularly burned areas and places in need of prescribed fire.
- New coverage of marine birds in the Gulf of America.



Indigo snake and gopher tortoise near a prescribed burn. Photo by Zickie Allgrove, Georgia Dept. of Natural Resources.

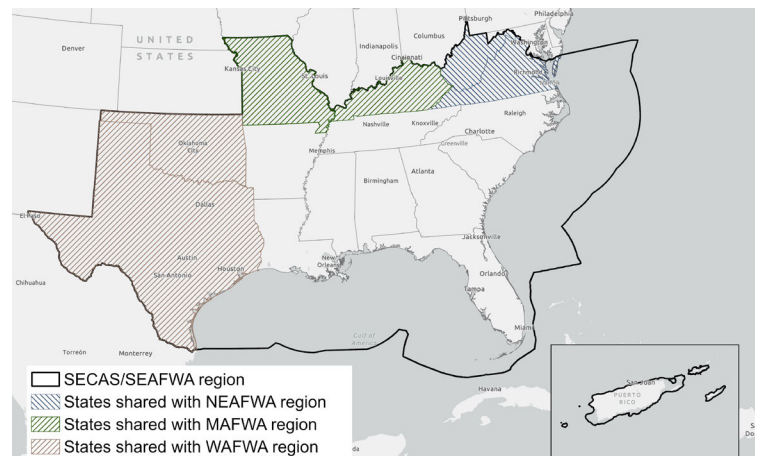
Updating the 2026 SECAS Goal Report

In 2018, SECAS established [an ambitious regional goal](#): a 10% or greater improvement in the health, function, and connectivity of Southeastern ecosystems by 2060. Every two years, SECAS releases an assessment of progress towards this goal called *Recent Trends in Southeastern Ecosystems*, or the SECAS Goal Report. Updates to the 2026 Goal Report will likely include new trends for fire history, imperiled amphibian and reptile habitat, and imperiled mammal habitat. It will also likely include updated trends for salt marsh area, coastal condition, and grassland and savanna birds.

Aligning with Neighboring Regional Conservation Initiatives

SECAS continues to collaborate with regional AFWA conservation partnerships, including the Midwest Landscape Initiative (MLI), the Northeast Landscape Committee, and WAFWA regional initiatives. With an intent to be unified, not uniform, SECAS works alongside these regions to share knowledge, increase efficiency, and strengthen conservation outcomes across landscapes that transcend regional lines.

For example, this year, SECAS leveraged existing funding and worked closely with MLI to pilot a [Midwest Blueprint Explorer](#) based on the existing Southeast Blueprint viewer. This powerful new tool will amplify MLI's capacity to support users and has received positive feedback from staff and partners.

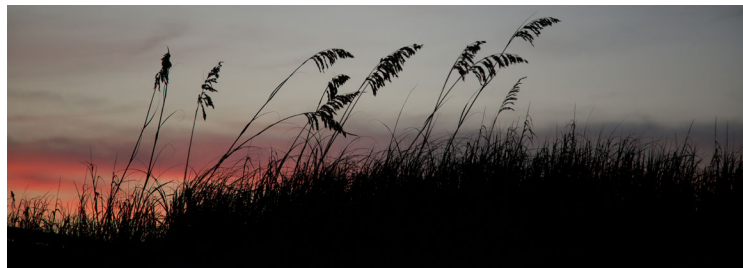


Aligning with Partner Priorities

Times of change offer an opportunity to refocus on the products and services that matter most to our partners.

Responding to Change

In the face of recent disruptions, SECAS staff are using multiple avenues to seek input on the focus of the SECAS partnership. Our goal is to better understand what critical partnership functions need to be maintained, and what can be scaled back. Staff will summarize and present this feedback for discussion during the SECAS Steering Committee meeting at SEAFWA.



Sea oats at sunset. Sunset Beach, NC. Photo by Ryan Hagerty, USFWS.

Advancing the State Fish & Wildlife Agency Action Plan

Earlier this year, the regional and national fish and wildlife agency associations responded to a request from U.S. Fish and Wildlife Service (USFWS) Director Brian Nesvik to recommend priority actions to the USFWS. SECAS staff, who are all currently supported by USFWS, are working with state wildlife agencies and others within the USFWS to advance these recommendations.

Director Nesvik has identified this work as a top priority, with completion targeted for summer 2028. The action plan seeks to ensure that:

- SECAS remains fully funded and operational, enabling consistent collaboration across states (recommended by SEAFWA).
- The Service supports regional and national landscape-scale conservation efforts including SECAS, MLI, the Northeast Landscape Wildlife Conservation Committee, and WAFWA efforts that integrate data, modeling, mapping, prioritization, coordination and on-the-ground conservation delivery that identify and conserve core habitats and key wildlife corridors (recommended by AFWA).
- Guided by the next generation SWAPs, habitat connectivity and landscape conservation design are integrated across the regions and nation through collaborative state and federal planning and science frameworks (recommended by AFWA).
- Federal species management priorities align with State Wildlife Action Plans, other state species management plans, and multistate/regional initiatives, and SWAPs are communicated as a state based strategic approach for preventing listings and expediting recovery (recommended by AFWA).

Our Steering Committee

- **Nicole Angeli (Chair):** Director, USVI Dept. of Planning & Natural Resources
- **Duck Locascio:** Forestry Program Manager, LA Dept. of Wildlife & Fisheries
- **Jason Sumners:** Director, MO Dept. of Conservation
- **Kyle Briggs:** Executive Director, NC Wildlife Resources Commission
- **Paul Johansen:** Chief, Wildlife Resources Section, WV Div. of Natural Resources
- **Mike Oetker:** Southeast Regional Director, USFWS

Meet Your SECAS Staff



Rua Mordecai,
Science Coordinator

Coordination,
facilitation, GIS,
product development



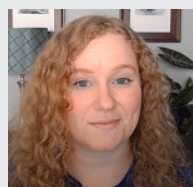
Louise Vaughn,
**Interim Coordinator
& User Support**

Coordination, user
support, facilitation,
promotion



Alex Lamle,
User Support

User support,
technical assistance,
facilitation



Amy Keister,
GIS Coordinator

GIS, technical
assistance, product
development



Hilary Morris,
**User Support &
Communications**

Communications,
facilitation, user
support, promotion



Adam Malcomb,
User Support

User support,
technical assistance,
promotion